join the union, whether I wanted to or not, I thought, was an infringement on my rights. I guess I also was a little uncertain as to why actors needed to have a union. But as I spoke to some of the older career actors I met at Warners and discovered how much they'd been exploited in the past, I began to change my mind. Major stars had no trouble negotiating good contracts and working conditions for themselves, but that wasn't the case for the supporting players, many of whom had been blacklisted by the studios and deprived of work after they'd tried to form a union.

As far as I was concerned, some of the studio bosses were abusing their power. Throughout my life, I guess there's been one thing that's troubled me more than any other: the abuse of people and the theft of their democratic rights, whether by a totalitarian government, an employer, or anyone else. I probably got it from my father; Jack never bristled more than when he thought working people were being exploited.

Once I'd become a believer in the union, I was appointed to the Screen Actors Guild's board of directors. I wasn't asked; I was drafted to represent the industry's younger contract players.

My first directors' meeting wasn't at all what I expected. I thought the union would be run by the lesser actors who'd been exploited by the studios, but instead a lot of Hollywood's top stars, like Cary Grant and Jimmy Cagney, were on the board. Most were big box-office draws who could easily command huge salaries and didn't need the Guild's help to negotiate their wages. But they enthusiastically gave their time and prestige to assure that lesser players like me got a fair shake. That night I told myself that if I ever became a star, I'd do as much as I could to help the actors and actresses at the bottom of the ladder.

The studios had a vested interest in helping contract players achieve stardom. But we were all captives of their decisions,